

SANDESH RAVIKUMAR

SUNITA ZACHARIA, *46*; SNEHA MATHEW, *43*

Homemakers, ***Bengaluru***

Dream fulfilled: **Floated Spice Boat, a company that sells homemade masalas, spice pastes and powders**

How Covid changed me

"Covid showed me the market potential for this venture. Simply to hear a customer say that my podi reminds them of their grandmother is so fulfilling! "

were crazy, but we were careful and went where occupancy was low, to escape infection. There was hardly any money coming in at this point, but that never mattered." There was another worry—an eight-year-old car on its last legs. "We zeroed in on the Volkswagen Taigun. It was way above our budget, but my daughter had her heart set on it, so we decided to splurge! Not just the base model, we went for the most expensive variant, with the sun roof et al. I usually calculate all my decisions carefully, and was going against my grain. That, too, at a time when everything, including finances, was so uncertain. But when I drove it home in time for Christmas, the smile on my daughter's face made me realise there are things you can't put a price on. The pandemic is a high price to pay to arrive at such a realisation, but it's all about being bold and taking that first step."

If family came first for many, others responded to the idea of the wider humanity, of community. In Visakhapatnam, Kameswara R., a retired banking manager, did a distance learning diploma in nursing so he could help others in the event of an emergency. The 66-year-old loved the experience of returning to education. "I had felt the lack of this skill ever since my mother died of a heart attack six years ago, but I never had the courage to study again. Now, I constantly tell my friends and family to start learning any new skill. It makes you feel younger, healthier and, in my case, certainly happier," says Kameswara.

Helping others, in fact, has become quite a trend. The India Giving Report 2021 by Charities Aid Foundation, based on an online survey of 2,000 Indians across cities, found that individual donations had gone up by 43 per cent—with many preferring local philanthropy. Most donated for emotional reasons: half the respondents said giving to others made them feel good personally.

When Hindustani classical musician-couple Shubhendra and Saskia Rao began the concept of 'e-baithaks', they, too, were thinking of others. In October 2020, when Ustad Faiyaz Wasifuddin Dagar performed in their Delhi home to a small gathering of 20 music lovers, the vocalist was in tears. He was performing 'live' after more than six months. And an audience, as any artist will attest, is the prime source of energy for a performer. The overwhelming response saw the couple set up monthly performances. Hosting baithaks had been a dream for the Raos, but their travels and work commitments never allowed space for it. "The pandemic changed that. We had all the time in the world, so I thought why not revive those sessions...with a new format," says Shubhendra. Rasa, in the Indian tradition, is a collective thing—produced in togetherness, not isolation. And perhaps something like a new raga has washed over all of us. ■

– *with* Aditi Pai, Romita Datta, Chumki Bharadwaj and Amarnath K. Menon